Welcome to Stamp Album Generator 2



A practical guide to collecting, reviewing, and generating stamp albums

Stamp Album Generator 2 gathers stamp data in a country or theme database, lets you review records, and creates album instructions for AlbumEasy. This guide explains setup, data collection, review, and output.

AlbumEasy is a separate application by Bundu Technology Ltd. Install it to lay out album pages and create PDF files. When configured, Stamp Album Generator 2 can launch it. Review the generated text and add any commands you need.

1. First-time setup

Stamp Album Generator 2 runs on Linux and Windows. Launch the downloaded application to open the web UI. On the first normal launch, it creates its local configuration, help PDF, and working files. Keep config.toml private if it contains account credentials.

1. Launch the application to open the startup page. To open the Review UI directly from a terminal, run stamp_album_gen2 --review-ui (on Windows, use stamp_album_gen2.exe).

2. On the startup page, choose and apply the Albums Root folder. You can change it later; use Refresh if a collection does not appear.

3. Select a collection and choose Open Review. To start one, choose Create New Country or Theme, enter a name, and select Create & Initialize.

4. If needed, save your StampWorld or Colnect login in Site Accounts. Credentials are kept in local config.toml; keep this file private.

2. Collect data

StampWorld

StampWorld pulls require a StampWorld account; save its credentials in Site Accounts. Use StampWorld Pull on the startup or Review page. Choose the year range and start the pull. If the suggested country URL is wrong, enter and save the correct StampWorld country-page URL. The saved URL changes the source page, not the collection name. A one-run CLI override is available with --stampworld-country-url.

Colnect

Import a Colnect CSV from the startup page or Review UI, using Colnect's Export for AlbumEasy format. Imports add review candidates; they do not automatically change album stamps. Inbox imports skip files already imported by SHA-256 checksum and do not generate pages unless requested. Auto-route moves files into country subfolders; leave it off to keep them in place.

You can also enter your own stamp data using the manual_import_template.csv created in UserImport. Follow UserImport/README.md, then import the completed CSV through the same Colnect workflow. Use a unique stable Col:manual-... ID for each manually entered candidate; do not invent Colnect listing numbers or links.

Other sources include US1847 and saved HTML (extractfile; --source-file is a shortcut). Check --help for requirements for other source values.

3. Review and update records

In the Review UI, compare Colnect candidates with existing stamps. Assign a candidate to the matching stamp, select the fields to update, and apply the changes. Use Add Colnect As Stamp for a genuinely new stamp. Imports alone do not update album stamps. Back up the country database before applying a large batch of edits.

4. Generate album pages and PDFs

Use the startup page or Review UI generation controls after importing or reviewing data. Generation uses the selected database and settings. Inspect the generated AlbumEasy text before printing. Creating a PDF requires AlbumEasy; configure albumeasy_cli_path for automatic launch, or open the text in AlbumEasy yourself.

When album text already exists, generation creates a timestamped backup before replacing it. Back up any other edited files and your database before making changes.

5. Useful command-line examples

Generate from an existing database: stamp_album_gen2 --db-path "Albums/Canada/Canada.db" --album-name "Canada"

Pull StampWorld data: stamp_album_gen2 --source stampworld --site-name "South Korea" --album-name "South Korea" --start-year 1970 --end-year 1980

Process an inbox and generate after successful imports: stamp_album_gen2 --source colnectexport --colnect-inbox "colnect_inbox" --colnect-generate-after-import

Inbox mode only imports unless you add --colnect-generate-after-import. Import one manual CSV with --

source colnectexport --colnect-csv path/to/file.csv --db-path Albums/Country/Country.db --album-name Country. Run stamp_album_gen2 --help for all options. Quote names and paths that contain spaces.

6. Configuration and file safety

Local config.toml stores settings such as the Albums Root, Colnect inbox, AlbumEasy command path, PDF options, and credentials. Create it from config_template.toml or run stamp_album_gen2 --init-config; --force-init-config backs up an existing file before replacing it. Keep credentials private. Back up databases and edited output before changing data.

7. Troubleshooting

No collection? Check Albums Root and select Refresh. Pull or import failure? Check the country, year range, account access, file path, and CSV format; read the status message and log. No PDF? Check AlbumEasy and albumeasy_cli_path. Consult README.md, docs/CLI_USAGE.md, and docs/guides/USER_DEFINED_CSV_IMPORT.md for more help.

8. Command-line reference

Run stamp_album_gen2 --help for the complete current list. The main options are --source (stampworld, touchstamps, extractfile, colnectexport, or us1847), --site-name for the source country, --album-name for the collection, and --db-path for the SQLite database. Use --start-year and --end-year to choose years; defaults are 1840 and the current year. Scrapers also accept --max-pages (0 means no explicit page cap) and --stop-after-no-hits (default 3 consecutive pages). Quote names and paths containing spaces. When running the binary directly, do not put an extra -- after its name.

StampWorld accepts --base-url to override URL construction and --stampworld-country-url for a one-run country-page URL override. The Review UI can save a country URL for future pulls. Use a full HTTPS URL under www.stampworld.com/en/stamps/<country>/, without a year-range path, query, credentials, or fragment. The URL changes the source page only; it does not change the country or album name.

Saved country URLs are keyed by the exact country name in slug_overrides.toml, not in the database. The application searches working-folder ancestors, then executable ancestors, and creates the file in the working folder if none exists. Saving preserves other settings but may reformat TOML comments. Invalid or unreadable settings cause an explicit error. Switching countries loads that country's saved URL; unsaved edits for the previous country are discarded. Clear and save a URL to return to automatic naming.

For output and confirmation, --overwrite-album allows replacement of album text, and --overwrite-images refreshes images. Existing album text is backed up with a timestamp before it is replaced. --yes or -y accepts the suggested correction when a source name appears misspelled. Use --init-config to create config.toml; combine it with --force-init-config to replace an existing file after a timestamped backup. --help and --version display built-in information.

Colnect import options

Use --colnect-csv PATH to import one CSV. When --db-path and --album-name are also supplied, the command proceeds to album generation. Use --colnect-inbox DIR to discover CSVs recursively and process them country by country. Without that option, colnectexport mode uses colnect_inbox_path from config.toml. Inbox mode imports only by default; add --colnect-generate-after-import to generate output for countries with a successful import.

Inbox options include --colnect-auto-route to move discovered files into country subfolders, --colnect-country COUNTRY to process just one country, and --colnect-create-country-db to create missing country databases. Duplicate files are skipped by SHA-256 checksum by default; --colnect-skip-duplicates keeps this behavior and --colnect-force-reimport imports them again. After a normal inbox import, generate pages by running the database output command for each country.

9. Review UI details

The Review UI compares existing StampWorld stamps on the left with imported Colnect candidates on the right. Each side shows stamp images, catalog codes, year, series, description, and available metadata. Use Prev and Next for stamps and the arrow controls for candidates. Assign a candidate to a stamp, clear an assignment before applying if needed, and select which fields to copy. More than one candidate may be assigned to the same stamp. Only checked fields are written when you choose Apply Matches To DB. Selectable fields include series, description, watermark, design, engraving, perforation, context, Colnect links, image URL, and Colnect metadata such as colors, format, emission, paper, gum, print run, face value, currency, and dimensions. Replace SG number controls whether the Colnect SG catalog value replaces the existing value. The right unmatched only filter hides candidates already linked to a stamp.

Default field selections can be changed in the [review_ui] section of config.toml. Series, description, Colnect links, Colnect image URL, and Colnect metadata are enabled by default. Watermark, design, engraving, perforation, context, replace SG number, and right unmatched only are disabled by default. Row striping colors can also be configured there.

Use Add Colnect As Stamp for a candidate with no matching StampWorld record. Enter its SG number, year, and series. Choose the current left-stamp image, upload an image to the album images folder, or create the new stamp without an image. Available Colnect metadata is added with the new record.

PDF filters and candidate deletion

In the Review screen PDF section, Emission and Format filters default to All. Choices are looked up dynamically from the current country's album records, including Colnect metadata and reference-data fallback; unmatched right-panel candidates are not album records. Multiple choices in one filter use OR; Emission, Format, and year range combine using AND. With a filter active, stamps with missing metadata are included only when Unknown / not recorded is selected. Filter choices are remembered per country in the browser, so browser local storage must be enabled and you must use the same server address and port. Refresh filter choices after imports or edits; generation also refreshes them. Unavailable remembered choices remain visible and selected; they are not silently changed to All. Filters affect generated AlbumEasy text and PDF from Generate PDF Now on the Review screen, not database records or the stamp/candidate panels. They do not apply to country-selection-screen generation or Generate & Close. If no stamps match, generation reports an error and leaves prior output unchanged.

Delete Colnect Candidate is a soft delete: the database row is retained but hidden from the candidate panel. Undo Delete restores the most recently deleted candidate during the current browser session. Reloading the page clears the undo stack. The Review UI adds missing Colnect metadata and deletion columns on startup without modifying existing records.

10. Manual CSV data

The application creates UserImport/manual_import_template.csv and UserImport/README.md on normal startup. These paths are relative to the runtime working folder, which may differ from the folder used to launch the program. Missing files are recreated on a later normal launch; existing files are never overwritten. Copy the template to a new file and keep its original headers. Use one row per individual stamp or variant and one country per file. Save as comma-separated UTF-8 CSV without a byte-order mark (BOM); do not save as XLSX or use semicolons. Preserve leading zeros by entering dates and catalog numbers as text. The template has 38 supported Colnect columns. The core headers are Name, Country, Series, Catalog Codes, Issued on, and Link. Keep all original headers and keep Name,Country as the first two unquoted headers. A manual candidate needs a unique stable Col:manual-... identifier in Catalog Codes, for example Col:manual-ch-0001. The Col: prefix is case-sensitive. Reuse that ID when editing the same stamp; use a different ID for each variant. Do not invent a Colnect listing number or fake link. Leave unknown optional values blank.

Catalog Codes can include real Sg:, Sn:, Mi:, or Yt: numbers as well as the stable Col: ID. Keep the country prefix when known. Quote cells containing commas, such as a list of catalog codes. The template has no local image-file field. See docs/guides/USER_DEFINED_CSV_IMPORT.md or the generated UserImport/README.md for all supported columns, examples, and import limits.

11. Country flags and cover images

Country lookup uses the bundled tab-delimited ISOCountryCodes.csv, which has no header and 246 supplied entries, including South Korea, North Korea, and historical entries such as Netherlands Antilles. The file is embedded at build time, so changing it requires rebuilding. Names and codes are case-insensitive; spaces, hyphens, and underscores are normalized. Existing aliases such as UK, USA, and Great Britain remain available. A local flags/flag_codes.json merges additional name-to-code overrides with the bundled map. STAMP_FLAGS_DIR can point to the flags folder or its parent.

For historical countries, occupations, or unsupported flag codes, add an explicit mapping or provide an album-local image; the application does not infer a historical flag. The flag cache checks local assets first, then neXperts PNG, neXperts SVG, and FlagCDN. Responses are validated before caching, and SVG flags are rasterized to PNG. Setting flag_cover_overwrite_flag = true refreshes cached flags; an unsuccessful refresh keeps the old file. If lookup or download fails, a valid album-local images/flag_placeholder.png or images/flag_placeholder.svg may be used. print_flag_cover and flag_cover_elements control cover and flag output. Cover assets follow the configured Albums Root, including STAMP_ALBUMS_ROOT.

12. Diagnostics and further help

PDF generation waits up to 300 seconds for a fresh PDF after AlbumEasy exits. For a large album or slow drive, increase the positive albumeasy_pdf_timeout_secs setting in global or album configuration. The timeout does not limit how long AlbumEasy runs, and an existing unchanged PDF is not considered new output. Enable --pdf-dx-logging for additional diagnostics; logs are written to Logs/stamp_album_gen2-*.log. The Review UI normally uses http://127.0.0.1:7878/. Use --review-ui-bind ADDR to choose another address or port. To build the application from source, install Rust and run cargo build --release. The optional GUI folder picker is enabled with cargo build --features rfd; builds without GUI support use console prompts only when a terminal is available. On Linux, GUI builds require the appropriate GTK libraries.

For command-line details see docs/CLI_USAGE.md and run stamp_album_gen2 --help. For configuration see config_template.toml, config_full_example.toml, and docs/guides/CONFIG_PARAMETERS_INVENTORY.md. For manual imports see docs/guides/USER_DEFINED_CSV_IMPORT.md. Back up your database and edited album files before applying large changes.

13. License and downloads

Download the application from https://github.com/amhbamhb/StampAlbumGen2/releases/latest. The project is licensed under the Laser Spider Stamp Collector License (LSSCL) v1.0. Individual stamp collectors may use it for personal use at no fee. Non-collector, business, corporate, institutional, educational, or commercial use requires a separate written paid agreement with Laser Spider LLC. See LICENSE and LASER_SPIDER_STAMP_COLLECTOR_LICENSE_v1.0.md for the full terms. Project website: https://stampalbumgenerator2.com/.

Acknowledgement: Stamp Album Generator 2 builds on AlbumEasy by Bundu Technology Ltd. Learn more at https://www.thestampweb.com/albumeasy.